

Comments for Planning Application DM2025/01591

Application Summary

Application Number: DM2025/01591

Address: Ambulance Station Dorset Road Belmont SM2 6JH

Proposal: Change of use from Sui Generis (Ambulance Station) to mixed use Classes F1 (Places of Worship) and F2 (Community Hub) involving the erection of a part one, part two storey front and side extension, increase in height to part of building and provision of cycle and refuse stores.

Case Officer: Polly Davidson

Customer Details

Name: Miss Shaista Naz

Address: Flat 3 Glenlyon House 8A Station Road Belmont SM2 6BH

Comment Details

Commenter Type:

Stance: Customer made comments in support of the Planning Application

Comment Reasons:

Comment: As someone who lives locally, I want to add my voice in support of planning application DM2025/01591. I think this proposal will be good for the neighbourhood.

The noise assessment used real-world measurements, not theoretical models. The consultants recorded actual sound levels from the congregation at their existing venue and assessed how that noise would transmit through the proposed building fabric. The result: below background noise at neighbouring properties.

Residents will no longer have emergency vehicles coming and going through the night. The facility will operate within defined hours, which is a notable improvement over the former ambulance station that ran 24 hours a day, seven days a week.

I have checked the timings and there is no conflict between Friday prayers and the school run. The prayer changeover is around 12:30 to 12:55, while school drop-off and pick-up are at 08:30 and 15:00 respectively. These do not coincide.

It is also worth mentioning that but that only works if there are local facilities to refer to. GPs increasingly refer patients to community activities as part of social prescribing. This proposal would create one in an area that currently has very little.

This application stands or falls on its planning merits, and on those merits it is strong. I expect the Council to assess it accordingly. The policy support is clear, the evidence is comprehensive, and the community benefit is well-documented.

The BNG assessment meets the statutory requirement, and the external greening will improve the appearance and ecological value of a site that currently offers very little in either regard. I welcome the environmental improvements included in this proposal.

The modal split for this facility is overwhelmingly sustainable. Half of all attendees at Friday prayers walk, and fewer than 12% drive alone. The proposed cycle storage will encourage even more sustainable travel. This is far better than many other developments the Council approves.

It is also worth mentioning that this proposal addresses that directly, with dedicated spaces and programmes. Women and elderly residents in faith communities can face particular barriers to accessing community facilities, especially when there is nothing suitable nearby.

I would also note that I think it is important that the planning officer considers the breadth of this proposal. The educational programmes, wellbeing sessions, and interfaith events are designed to bring different parts of the community together. This is truly inclusive provision.

Furthermore, the development reduces on-site parking and removes restrictive yellow lines, actually improving the kerbside situation for residents. The claim that this development will create a new parking problem ignores the fact that the previous use had 21 parking spaces and generated regular vehicle movements.

On this point, the Transport Statement is evidence-based and thorough. It surveyed real conditions at peak time and demonstrated that on-street parking capacity is more than sufficient. I am satisfied that the proposal will not cause a parking problem.

The proposed extension is not overbearing. It is a part one, part two storey addition that sits comfortably within the existing site. The inclusion of cycle storage, refuse stores, and external greening shows that the applicant has thought carefully about how the building sits in its surroundings.

I would also note that the planning statement provides clear demographic evidence that the local Muslim community has outgrown the available facilities. But this is not just about faith provision. The need is real and well-documented. The community hub will serve all residents with educational, social, and wellbeing activities.

I find it odd that some objectors are concerned about the impact of a community facility when the previous use was a full-time ambulance station with sirens, heavy vehicles, and overnight operations. The proposed use is quieter, less disruptive, and operates within defined hours.

I strongly encourage the Council to approve this application. It will bring a unused site back to life and serve the community for years to come.